

Congressional Attention to Abortion after *Dobbs*: How Representational and Electoral Incentives Selectively Shape Issue Attention

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Abstract

Abstract: Landmark Supreme Court rulings can significantly alter policy, expand or restrict rights, and reshape public opinion. Yet whether—and how—such rulings shift congressional attention on specific issues remains unclear. We examine this question in the case of *Dobbs v. Jackson Women’s Health Organization* (2022), which eliminated the federal constitutional right to abortion. We argue that, after *Dobbs*, legislators increased attention to abortion selectively, only when two incentives aligned: gender-based representational considerations and party-based electoral incentives. These incentives converged for female Democrats. Female Republicans, however, faced electoral risks in foregrounding abortion, and male legislators faced weaker gender-linked representational incentives. Using nearly 1.6 million statements from U.S. House committee hearings, we treat the draft opinion leak (May 2, 2022) as a treatment in difference-in-differences models comparing pre- and post-leak attention by party and gender. Pre-treatment trends show no systematic differences. After the leak, female Democrats increased abortion-related references by two percentage points relative to female Republicans, with no change among male legislators. Elevated attention to abortion among female Democrats persisted through the 119th Congress (2025). We also show that, across six non-abortion policy areas, the same gender- and electoral-based patterns do not emerge, providing additional evidence that *Dobbs* is the primary driver of the observed increase in abortion attention. Our results are robust to an alternative measure of issue attention: cosponsorship of abortion-related bills. These findings indicate that legislators’ responses to *Dobbs* were selective and shaped by gender- and electoral-based incentives.

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On May 2, 2022, a draft opinion in *Dobbs v. Jackson Women's Health Organization* was leaked to the public. Two months later, the Supreme Court issued its official decision, overturning *Roe* and *Casey* and eliminating the federal constitutional right to abortion. In the wake of *Dobbs*, scholars have examined how the ruling affected voters' attitudes toward abortion and the Court (Clark, Paluck, Westwood, Sen, Malhotra and Jessee 2024; Gibson 2025; Levendusky, Patterson Jr, Margolis, Pasek, Winneg and Jamieson 2024), as well as candidates' campaign platforms (Meisels 2025). Existing evidence shows a sharp and durable partisan divergence: Republicans' trust in and perceived legitimacy of the Court increased, while Democrats' evaluations declined across each dimension (Clark et al. 2024; Levendusky et al. 2024; Gibson 2025). The ruling also reshaped candidates' campaign platforms, with Democratic primary candidates increasingly emphasizing abortion while Republican primary candidates attempted to avoid the issue (Meisels 2025).

The extent to which landmark Supreme Court rulings influence congressional issue attention remains unclear. We examine this question in the case of *Dobbs*. The decision generated intense media attention (Levendusky et al. 2024), polarized public opinion along party lines (Clark et al. 2024; Levendusky et al. 2024; Gibson 2025), and produced immediate implications for state-level policy (Gardner, McCrary and Spencer 2025; Simonovits, Doherty and Bor 2025). These factors suggest that *Dobbs* likely garnered congressional attention, enabling us to explore the factors that shaped legislators' responses. We argue that legislators did not uniformly increase attention to abortion after *Dobbs*; rather, they did so selectively, only when both gender-based representational incentives and party-based electoral incentives aligned.

First, we expect legislators' response to *Dobbs* to be shaped by their gender identity. Because female legislators are more likely than male legislators to prioritize gender-salient issues (Lawless 2015; Swers 2023), they have a gender-based incentive to highlight abortion after *Dobbs*. Importantly, we expect female legislators to increase their attention to abortion relative to male legislators regardless of their policy position. While female Republicans are likely to frame their abortion references in a pro-life direction and female Democrats in a pro-choice direction, their gender identity should lead both groups to elevate attention to the issue.

Second, we also expect legislators’ response to *Dobbs* to be conditioned by their electoral interests (Mayhew 2004). Existing work highlights that, after *Dobbs*, legislators’ abortion-related electoral environment varied by party: Republican candidates largely deemphasized abortion on the campaign trail, while Democrats elevated the issue (Meisels 2025). This pattern likely reflects the fact that Republican candidates anticipated electoral costs for foregrounding the issue, whereas Democrats anticipated potential electoral gains. And Republican candidates were correct to anticipate an electoral penalty: in the 2022 midterm elections, their vote share was, on average, five percentage points lower in states with abortion-related measures on the ballot (Gardner, McCrary and Spencer 2025). Collectively, these findings suggest that Republican candidates both anticipated and faced an electoral penalty for highlighting abortion.

Therefore, we argue that legislators increased their attention to abortion only when these two incentives—gender and electoral—converged. This alignment occurred only for female Democrats. Female Republicans faced electoral risks in foregrounding abortion, and male legislators of both parties faced weaker gender-linked representational incentives. Accordingly, we expect female Democrats to increase their attention to abortion after *Dobbs* relative to female Republicans, with no change among male legislators.

To evaluate these expectations, we use a bigram classifier to identify abortion references in nearly 1.6 million statements from U.S. House committee hearings spanning the 105th (1997) through the 119th (2025) Congresses. We employ difference-in-differences (DiD) specifications to estimate changes in abortion attention following *Dobbs*. We analyze *New York Times* coverage of abortion to show that legislators were most likely “treated” by the leaked draft (May 2, 2022). Because all legislators were exposed to the leak, our design does not compare treated versus untreated units; rather, the causal estimand captures the average difference in the within-legislator change in abortion attention from pre- to post-*Dobbs* between Democrats and Republicans, estimated separately for female and male legislators.

Numerous tests confirm that, prior to the leak, there were no systematic differences in abortion references by gender or party. After *Dobbs*, female Democrats increased their abortion-related

references by approximately two percentage points relative to female Republicans, with no change among male legislators. To ensure that the observed changes in abortion attention are specific to *Dobbs*, we examine six non-abortion policy areas over the same period and find that the gender- and electoral-based patterns do not appear, offering further evidence the increase in abortion attention is due to *Dobbs*. This effect persists through the 119th Congress (2025) and is substantively larger than changes in congressional attention following other high-profile court cases or political movements.¹ Our findings are also robust to an alternative measure of congressional issue attention: cosponsorship of abortion-related bills. These results suggest that landmark judicial decisions can increase congressional attention on an issue. However, such attention is unlikely to be uniform across all legislators; instead, in the case of *Dobbs*, legislators selectively allocate issue attention based on their gender identity and electoral considerations.

Research Design

We identify whether nearly 1.6 million committee hearing statements drawn from 17,408 hearings in the U.S. House of Representatives across the 105th through the 119th Congresses reference abortion (Park 2021; Lollis 2025). Our dataset includes all hearings in the 105th–118th Congresses and all hearings held on or before April 29, 2025, in the 119th Congress (the date of collection). To label statements, we employ a bigram dictionary classification method (Lollis 2025). First, we created a training set of randomly sampled statements ($n = 20,000$) and prompted GPT-5 to label whether each referenced abortion.² Human coders labeled a 2,000-statement subset of the training set, confirming that GPT-5 correctly classified abortion statements ($AUC = 0.94$)³. We then extracted abortion bigrams ($n = 1,829$)—two-word sequences that indicate abortion (e.g., `pro life`, `abortion ban`, `planned parenthood`)—from the positive training statements and

¹To benchmark the substantive effect of our findings, we use a parsimonious dictionary of LGBTQ and racial issues to compare changes in congressional attention before and after *Obergefell v. Hodges* (2015) and Black Lives Matter. The increase in attention to abortion after *Dobbs* exceeds the changes observed for LGBTQ or racial justice issues. See Appendix Section “Contextualizing Magnitude of Effect” for more information.

²Recent work demonstrates that GPT-5 outperforms human coders on complex text-classification tasks, including identifying relevance, stance, topics, and framing (Gilardi, Alizadeh and Kubli 2023).

³The Area Under the Curve (AUC) measures how well a model distinguishes between positive and negative labels; a value of 1.0 indicates perfect classification.

used this dictionary to classify the full corpus.⁴ Comparing GPT-5-coded and bigram-predicted labels in a held-out validation set confirms that the classifier accurately identified abortion statements in the full corpus (AUC = 0.95).⁵ In total, the bigram classifier identified 5,036 abortion statements. We construct two measures capturing the proportion of legislators’ committee statements referencing abortion:

- ***Attention to Abortion (Pre-Post Dobbs)***: measures the proportion of a legislator’s hearing statements that reference abortion before and after the *Dobb*’s decision leaked.
- ***Attention to Abortion (by Term)***: measures the proportion of a legislator’s hearing statements that reference abortion in each congressional term.

We estimate DiD models with two specifications—(i) a pre–post model with legislator fixed effects and (ii) a two-way fixed effects (TWFE) model with legislator and congressional-term fixed effects—to assess how legislators’ attention to abortion changed following *Dobbs*. In our design, *Dobbs* treated all legislators. As a result, the causal estimand is the average difference in the change in abortion attention from the pre- to post-*Dobbs* period between Democrats and Republicans, estimated separately for female and male legislators. Our estimate should be interpreted as a relative difference rather than an absolute causal effect. The primary identification threat to our design, given that we do not estimate the absolute causal effect, is that another factor could have driven shifts in issue attention across multiple policy areas at the same time. To address this, we examine six non-abortion policy areas and find no comparable shifts, providing reassurance that the observed changes are specifically attributable to *Dobbs*.⁶

The treatment date is May 2, 2022, when the draft opinion in *Dobbs* leaked. Before the leak, legislators could not have responded to the ruling’s content because it was not publicly known. To

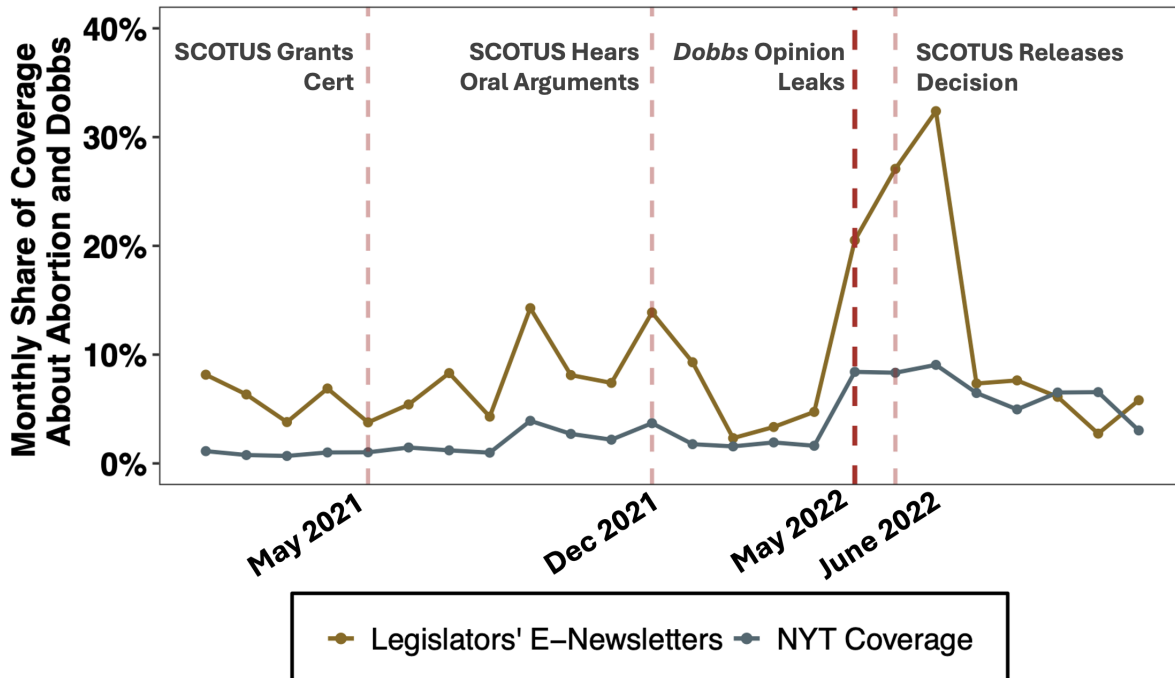
⁴Since we are interested in congressional attention to abortion, we measure the volume of statements, not their policy direction or tone. Given that parties are internally united in their abortion policy stances (Swers 2023), we suspect that most Republicans’ statements favor restricting abortion access while Democrats’ statements favor expanding it.

⁵Additional validation for the bigram dictionary classifier appears in Appendix Section “Labeling Abortion Statements.”

⁶See Appendix Section “Placebo Test: Non-Abortion Issue Areas.”

confirm that legislators were treated by the leak rather than when the Court released its decision (June 24, 2022), we compiled the monthly share of *New York Times* (NYT) articles referencing “abortion” or “*Dobbs v. Jackson*,” as well as the monthly share of legislators’ e-newsletters referencing the same terms (Cormack 2025). NYT coverage of abortion captures when legislators were most likely to learn about the content of the *Dobbs* decision, while legislators’ e-newsletters indicate whether legislators transmitted that information to constituents, offering behavioral evidence of treatment. If legislators were treated by the leaked decision, the initial spike in coverage and constituent communication should occur in May 2022. Figure 1 confirms this pattern: from April to May 2022, NYT abortion coverage rose by 6.8 percentage points (a 425% increase), and legislators’ mentions of abortion in their e-newsletters rose by 19.8 percentage points (a 421% increase).

Figure 1: Determining Treatment Date: NYT Coverage and Legislators’ Newsletters Referencing Abortion



Note: Monthly share of congressional electronic newsletters sent to constituents (N = 25,680) and *New York Times* articles (N = 182,329), from January 2021 through December 2022 that reference “abortion” or “*Dobbs v. Jackson*”. Abortion coverage from both sources rose sharply after the leak, indicating that the disclosure of the draft opinion—not the final decision—informed legislators of the ruling.

In the DiD models, the dependent variable is the proportion of a legislator’s committee hearing statements that reference abortion. The independent variable is an interaction between a post-*Dobbs* indicator and a Democratic Party indicator. Models are estimated separately by gender. In the pre-post specification, each legislator contributes two observations: the proportion of statements referencing abortion before and after *Dobbs*. In the TWFE specification, the unit of analysis is at the legislator-term level, with both legislator and congressional-term fixed effects.

We estimate a TWFE DiD model alongside the pre-post specification, despite a single (non-staggered) treatment date, for two reasons. First, term fixed effects absorb cross-term differences in statement volume, which is necessary given that the pre-post model pools more pre-treatment terms (12) than post-treatment terms (3). Second, term fixed effects adjust for time-varying shocks across congressional terms that could confound pre-post estimates. With a single treatment date, our TWFE DiD is not subject to the heterogeneous-effects bias concerns that arise in staggered-adoption designs (Hassell and Holbein 2025). Models are estimated with OLS and robust standard errors clustered by legislator.⁷

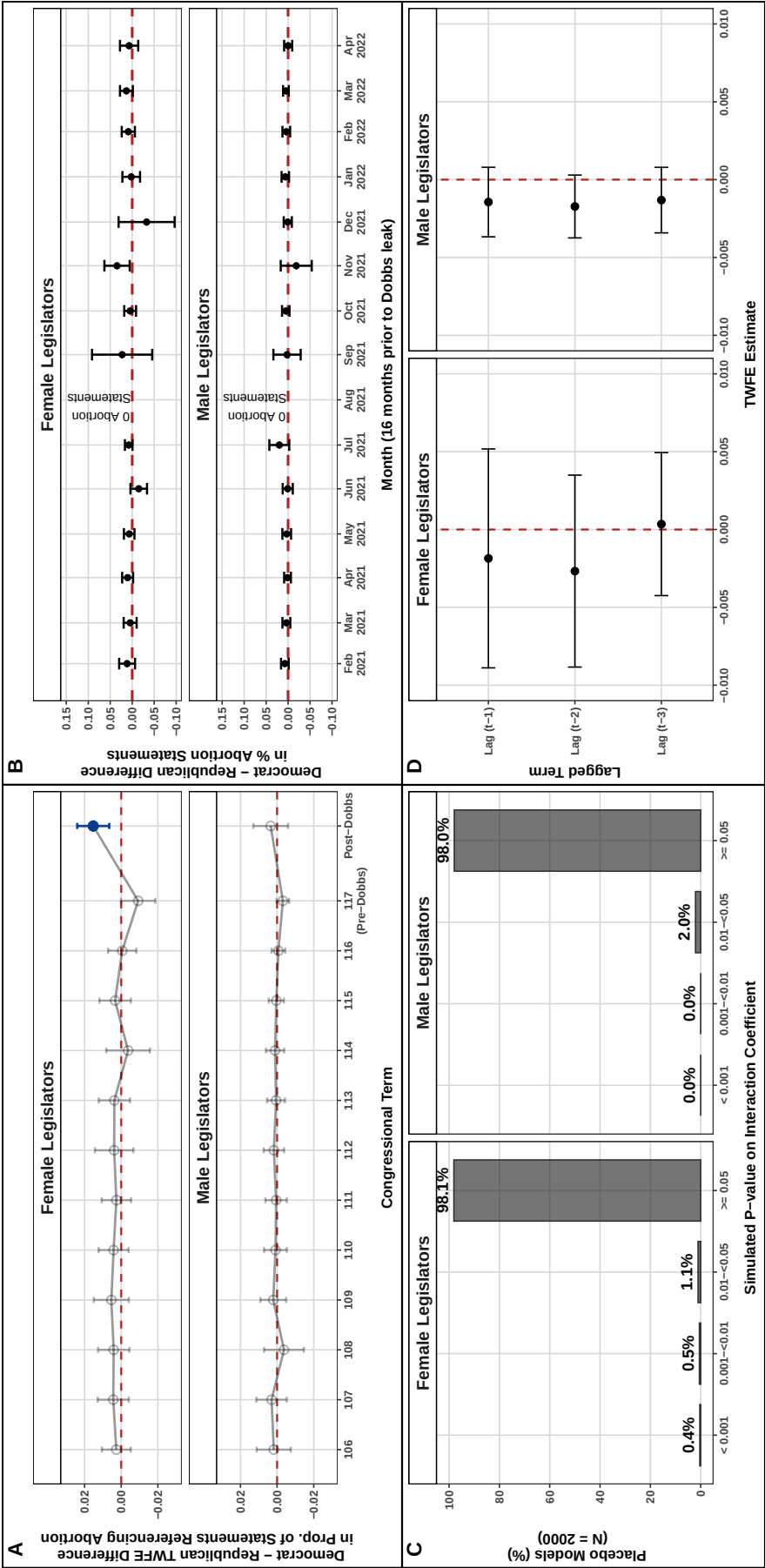
Identification in DiD designs hinges on the assumption that the groups of interest exhibit no pre-treatment differences—or, if differences exist, that these differences follow parallel trends. To evaluate whether this assumption holds in our research design, we conduct four complementary tests, reported in Figure 2 (Hassell and Holbein 2025).⁸ Panel A reports term-specific, pre-*Dobbs* TWFE DiD estimates of the party gap in abortion-related statements, using the 105th Congress as the reference category. There are no statistically significant party differences by gender in any pre-*Dobbs* term. Panel B examines whether variation in abortion references by party and gender emerges in the 16 months leading up to the decision, plotting TWFE DiD estimates over this period. January 2021 is the reference category. Again, there are no systematic pre-*Dobbs* differences. Panel C assesses pre-*Dobbs* differences by randomly assigning treatment dates prior to the decision and estimating party differences in pre-post DiD models by gender. Across 2,000

⁷To ensure that committee selection effects or committee-specific issue agendas do not confound our findings, we estimate models including committee fixed effects (see Appendix Table 3). Results remain substantively unchanged.

⁸For a more exhaustive discussion of DiD assumptions and parallel trends for our research design see Appendix Section “Difference-in-Differences Design”.

simulations, 98% of p-values on the interaction term of interest (Democrat x Post Dobbs) were not statistically significant. Finally, Panel D plots term-based lagged TWFE estimates of party differences in abortion references by gender. All lagged interactions are null, indicating that the effect did not emerge before the leak. Collectively, all four tests provide strong evidence that parallel trends hold for our research design.

Figure 2: Assessing Parallel Trends



Note: Panels A–D assess the validity of the parallel trends assumption for our research design. Panel A plots the party-based difference in abortion references using a TWFE model by gender. Panel B presents a 16-month event study reporting party-based differences using a TWFE model estimated by gender. Panel C shows estimated p-values from a simulation in which the treatment date is randomly assigned to 2,000 different pre-*Dobbs* dates. Panel D reports term-based lagged estimates from a TWFE model. Results indicate the parallel trends assumption is met for our research design.

Results

Table 1 reports estimates for both DiD model specifications; results are consistent across models. In the pre–post specification, female Republicans’ share of statements referencing abortion decreases by 0.87 percentage points after *Dobbs*, while female Democrats’ share increases by 1.32 percentage points. This yields a party-based difference among female legislators after *Dobbs*, reported as the Post *Dobbs* $\times$ Democrat interaction, of 2.19 percentage points ($p = 0.000$). In the TWFE model, the estimated increase in female Democrats’ abortion references after *Dobbs* is 0.8 percentage points ($p = 0.02$). Both of these models suggest that, relative to female Republicans, female Democrats increased their attention to abortion post-*Dobbs*. Further, across both model specifications subset to include only male legislators, the difference between Democrat and Republican legislators is not statistically significant. Results are substantively unchanged when adding committee fixed effects (alongside legislator and term fixed effects), indicating that neither committee selection effects nor committee-level hearing agendas confound our findings.⁹

To provide additional reassurance that the observed changes in abortion attention are specific to *Dobbs*, we examine six non-abortion policy areas over the same period. If broader shifts in overall issue attention were driving the results, we would expect similar gender- and party-based divergences across other issues. We find no such patterns: estimates for female and male legislators alike are not statistically significant. These placebo tests support our interpretation that the *Dobbs* decision specifically drove the increase in abortion attention among female Democrats.¹⁰

⁹See Appendix Table 3

¹⁰See Appendix Section “Placebo Tests: Non-Abortion Issue Areas”

Table 1: DiD Estimates of Party-Based Changes in Abortion Attention Before and After *Dobbs* by Gender

	Female Legislators		Male Legislators	
	Pre-Post	TWFE	Pre-Post	TWFE
Post- <i>Dobbs</i>	-0.009* (0.004)	-0.010* (0.004)	0.005* (0.003)	-0.004 (0.003)
Democrat	-0.008** (0.003)	-0.009* (0.004)	0.009*** (0.003)	-0.003** (0.001)
Post-<i>Dobbs</i> × Democrat	0.022*** (0.005)	0.008* (0.004)	0.004 (0.005)	-0.000 (0.001)
Intercept	0.010*** (0.002)	0.010* (0.004)	0.01*** (0.001)	0.004 (0.003)
Observations	226	1117	562	4562
Adjusted R^2	0.58	0.40	0.52	0.29
Legislator FE	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Term FE	No	Yes	No	Yes

Note: OLS estimates report the interaction effect of party after *Dobbs* by gender based on pre–post and two-way fixed-effects (TWFE) difference-in-differences models. After *Dobbs*, female Democrats increased their attention to abortion by two percentage points, while effects among male legislators were not statistically significant. The model includes robust standard errors clustered by legislator (printed in parentheses). * $p < 0.05$, ** $p < 0.01$, *** $p < 0.001$.

Using pre-*Dobbs* statement volume to benchmark the substantive per-member effects, the model estimates suggest that the average female Democrat makes about 24 additional abortion statements per term after *Dobbs*, while the average female Republican makes about 4 fewer. At the party level, female Democrats collectively made nearly 300 additional abortion statements and female Republicans 100 fewer.¹¹ To benchmark the magnitude of this effect against other landmark court decisions and political events, legislators’ attention to abortion after *Dobbs* exceeds the party- and gender-based shifts in attention to LGBTQ and racial justice issues after *Obergefell* and Black Lives Matter, respectively.¹²

We assess the durability of these effects by estimating separate pre–post DiD models for each

¹¹Although we use hearing statements to measure legislators’ attention to abortion, we do not establish whether increased attention translates into substantive policy change. Increased attention to abortion in hearings may not correlate with effective lawmaking on the issue.

¹²See Appendix Table 10

post-*Dobbs* Congress: the latter half of the 117th, all of the 118th, and the portion of the 119th in our corpus. We then conduct Wald tests of (i) joint significance of all post-*Dobbs* interactions and (ii) equality of effects across the three post-*Dobbs* periods. Consistent with our results, the joint post-*Dobbs* effect is statistically significant for female legislators (Wald $\chi^2(3) = 12.88, p = 0.004$) and not statistically significant for male legislators ($\chi^2(3) = 4.01, p = 0.26$). Effects are not statistically distinguishable across the three post-*Dobbs* periods for both female and male legislators (Female Legislators: $\chi^2(2) = 0.45, p = 0.80$; Male Legislators: $\chi^2(2) = 3.93, p = 0.14$), indicating that the treatment effect among female Democrats persists through the 119th Congress without detectable decay and is absent among male legislators.¹³ Results are robust when using cosponsorship as an alternative measure of attention: after *Dobbs*, female Democrats cosponsored more abortion bills than female Republicans, with no comparable change among male legislators.¹⁴

Conclusions

Existing research finds that voters' and candidates' responses to *Dobbs* were primarily driven by party. We show that Supreme Court decisions can trigger selective shifts in congressional issue attention. Legislators' responses to *Dobbs* were shaped by both gender- and electoral-based incentives. Gendered representational considerations and partisan electoral incentives converged for female Democrats but clashed for female Republicans, placing female Democrats at the forefront of Congress's response. The absence of a similar effect among male legislators—who faced comparable party-based electoral incentives—underscores that legislators' reactions to *Dobbs* were jointly structured by gender and party.

Understanding whether and how legislators respond to *Dobbs* matters for several reasons. First, *Dobbs* is a case in which the Court moved policy away from majority opinion on abortion (Jessee, Malhotra and Sen 2022; Clark et al. 2024). Whether (and which) legislators respond when the Court retrenches rights supported by most Americans speaks directly to Congress's capacity to represent public opinion. Second, our findings highlight the constraints descriptive representatives

¹³See Appendix Section “Durability of DiD Effects”

¹⁴See Appendix Table 11

face when parties strongly structure behavior: when identity-based incentives and partisan goals conflict, responsiveness on identity-linked issues may be muted. Future work should examine how *Dobbs* reshaped abortion politics in state legislatures, which now hold primary policymaking authority on the issue.

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Data

Committee Hearing Transcripts and Statements

We analyze nearly 1.6 million committee hearing statements drawn from 17,408 hearings held in the U.S. House of Representatives across the 105th–119th Congresses. Transcripts for the 105th–117th Congresses were obtained from publicly available replication files associated with Park (2021, 2025) (Park 2021; Ban, Park and You 2025). Transcripts for the 118th and 119th Congresses were scraped by the authors from `govinfo.gov` using the procedures described in Park (2021) (Park 2021). Scraping was completed on April 29, 2025; consequently, coverage for the 119th Congress includes hearings held on or before that date. Each hearing was parsed into individual statements (i.e., each unique time a legislator speaks). Witness statements were omitted. Statements were linked to legislators via GovTrack identification numbers, and legislators’ gender and party were subsequently merged in.

New York Times Coverage and Legislators’ E-Newsletters

We supplement our committee hearing transcripts and statements dataset with an additional dataset that captures abortion coverage in the *New York Times*. Specifically, we collect the total monthly count of all *New York Times* articles published between January 2021 and December 2022, as well as the monthly count of unique articles that include either of the following two search strings: `abortion` and `Dobbs v. Jackson`. These measures capture variation in national media attention to abortion over time. Second, we identify the total monthly count of Members of Congress’ e-newsletter releases to their constituents using D.C. Inbox, a database that archives all congressional e-newsletters in real time (Cormack 2025). We apply the same search strings and monthly date parameters to identify abortion- and *Dobbs*-related e-newsletters. Because e-newsletters reflect messages that members choose to send directly to constituents, they provide a complementary indicator of when legislators were treated with information about *Dobbs*. For each data source, we calculate a monthly proportion representing the share of all articles (or e-newsletters) that mention abortion or *Dobbs* during that month. The numerator is the sum of all

articles or e-newsletters matching the search criteria, and the denominator is the total count of all articles or e-newsletters published in that month, regardless of content. In total, we collect 182,329 NYT articles and 25,680 legislators' newsletters. These two data sources allow us to situate legislators' behavior within the broader information environment and to assess the timing of information flows around both the leak and the Court's final decision. We implement this approach for the six months preceding the first major action in the case (certiorari granted) and the six months following the Court's final action (the official decision release).

Labeling Abortion Statements

Bigram Dictionary Classification of Abortion Statements

We use a bigram dictionary classifier to identify legislators' committee hearing statements that reference abortion (Lollis 2025). We evaluated several text classification strategies (including large language models), but selected a transparent bigram dictionary classification because it most accurately labeled abortion statements. First, we preprocessed the text by converting all words to lowercase, removing non-alphabetic characters, collapsing extra whitespace, and dropping stop-words, numbers, and punctuation. We then constructed a labeled training set by stratified sampling of 20,000 statements: 30% contained the term " `abortion`," and the remaining 70% were drawn at random from the corpus to ensure sufficient positive cases for training and evaluation. We used GPT-5 to label the 20,000 statements in the training set as abortion-related (1) or not (0) under explicit guidance to tag only unambiguous references. We use GPT-5 to classify statements because recent work demonstrates that ChatGPT outperforms human coders on classification tasks (Gilardi, Alizadeh and Kubli 2023). We held out 2,000 statements for out-of-sample validation. We randomly selected 2,000 statements from the 18,000 GPT-5 coded training statements and instructed human coders to label them. There was high classification agreement between GPT-5 and human coders (AUC = 0.94). In total, 2,678 of the 18,000 statements (17.4%) were labeled as abortion-related.

From the 2,678 positive statements, we extracted all bigrams (two-word sequences) yielding 81,103 bigram tokens. We then manually reviewed and removed bigrams that did not reliably indicate abortion, resulting in a dictionary of 1,829 abortion bigrams. The ten most frequent bigrams were `planned parenthood`, `pro life`, `roe wade`, `abortion ban`, `fund abortion`, `abortion service`, `hyde amendment`, `forced abortion`, `access abortion`, and `abortion clinic`. For classification, each corpus statement was coded as abortion-related if (i) contained the token "abortion" or (ii) contained any abortion bigram; all other statements were not coded as abortion statements. The bigram classifier accurately predicted abortion statements

in a validation set (that was held back prior to bigram selection) comparing GPT-5 and bigram-predicted classifications. Validation statistics include: Accuracy = 0.979; Precision = 0.904; Recall = 0.912; F1 = 0.907; AUC = 0.953; Cohen’s Kappa = 0.9.

Our classifier identifies whether a statement references abortion; it does not code tone or policy position (e.g., pro-life vs. pro-choice). This design choice reflects two considerations. First, our outcome is legislators’ attention to abortion regardless of valence (positive/negative), function (substantive/symbolic), or policy direction (pro-life/pro-choice). Second, given that parties are increasingly internally homogeneous on policy issues (Lee 2016), especially highly partisan issues like abortion (Swers 2023), we expect that Republican statements are framed as pro-life while Democratic statements are framed as pro-choice. An additional measure of policy direction would add little information. Therefore, because our analyses focus on attention rather than stance, we do not code tone or policy direction.

Validating Abortion Labels

To validate our abortion labels, we held out 2,000 statements in a validation set prior to model training (i.e., these statements did not contribute to the bigram dictionary). We then compared GPT-5 labels to bigram-based predictions. The classifier closely matched the GPT-5 labels: accuracy = 0.979; precision = 0.904; recall = 0.912; F1 = 0.907; AUC = 0.953; Cohen’s κ = 0.90. These statistics indicate that (i) GPT-5 produced reliable training labels and (ii) the bigram classifier accurately identified abortion statements in the corpus. Importantly, because the curated dictionary contains only bigrams that explicitly reference abortion (each reviewed by the authors), statements are coded as abortion-related only when they contain a hand-validated abortion bigram—minimizing the risk of false positives. To illustrate the dictionary’s specificity, we list below the 50 most frequently occurring abortion bigrams: "plan parenthood" "pro life" "roe wade" "abort ban" "abort care" "reproduct health" "fund abort" "hyde amend" "abort servic" "birth abort" "perform abort" "partial birth" "provid abort" "abort provid" "gag rule" "forc abort" "access abort" "abort clinic" "ban abort" "pro choic" "global gag" "reproduct right" "seek

abort" "pro abort" "unborn children" "anti abort" "fetal tissu"
"reproduct healthcar" "termin pregnanc" "abort abort" "abort right"
"late term" "term abort" "dobb decis" "cover abort" "overturn roe"
"abort coverag" "select abort" "abort access" "includ abort" "life
mother" "access reproduct" "pai abort" "restrict abort" "legal abort"
"abort feder" "abort procedur" "protect life" "abort perform" "abort
polici"

Outcome Measures

We construct our outcome measure, *Attention to Abortion*, using all U.S. House committee hearing statements made between the 105th and 119th Congresses. We restrict the sample to include only members who served in at least one congressional term before and after *Dobbs*. Our primary outcome, *Attention to Abortion*, measures the proportion of legislators’ hearing statements that reference abortion. Statements are classified as pre-*Dobbs* or post-*Dobbs* using May 2, 2022—the date of the draft opinion leak—as the treatment. We use two DiD specifications: a pre-post design and a two-way fixed effects (TWFE) design.

For the pre-post DiD design, we aggregate statements across all Congresses before and after the *Dobbs* leak, collapsing to a single pre- and post-period observation per legislator:

$$Y_{ip} = \frac{1}{N_{ip}} \sum_{s=1}^{N_{ip}} A_{ips}, \quad (1)$$

where $p \in \{\text{pre}, \text{post}\}$ indicates whether statement s occurred before or after the *Dobbs* threshold, and N_{ip} denotes the total number of hearing statements made by legislator i during that period. The *Attention to Abortion (Pre-Post Dobbs)* outcome variable measures the proportion of a legislator’s hearing statements that reference abortion before and after the Dobb’s decision leaked.

For the two-way fixed effects (TWFE) design, we compute abortion attention for each legislator i in each Congress t :

$$Y_{it} = \frac{1}{N_{it}} \sum_{s=1}^{N_{it}} A_{its}, \quad (2)$$

where $A_{its} = 1$ if statement s made by legislator i in Congress t references abortion and 0 otherwise, and N_{it} is the total number of hearing statements made by legislator i in Congress t . The *Attention to Abortion (by Term)* outcome variable measures the proportion of a legislator’s hearing statements that reference abortion in each congressional term.

Each approach captures the same underlying construct—legislators’ proportional attention to abortion before and after *Dobbs*—but with a different unit of analysis. The unit of analysis for the pre-post design is legislator-treatment date. The unit of analysis for the TWFE design is legislator-term.

Difference-in-Differences Design

We estimate the effect of *Dobbs v. Jackson Women’s Health Organization* on legislators’ abortion attention using two complementary difference-in-differences (DiD) specifications: a pre–post model with legislator fixed effects and a two-way fixed effects (TWFE) model with legislator and term fixed effects. Our design is a modified DiD because all legislators receive the treatment (i.e., the leaked *Dobbs* decision). Consequently, the causal estimand is the average *difference in the change* in abortion attention from the pre- to post-*Dobbs* period between Democrats and Republicans, estimated separately for female and male legislators. Because this estimand captures the differential change in attention between Democrats and Republicans rather than the absolute effect of the treatment, it should not be interpreted as an absolute causal effect. The primary identification threat is that another factor could have driven shifts in issue attention across multiple policy areas, including abortion, simultaneously. To address this concern, we examine six non-abortion policy areas and find no comparable shifts, providing reassurance that the observed changes are uniquely attributable to *Dobbs* (see Appendix Section “Placebo Test: Non-Abortion Issue Areas”).

Sample inclusion: The universe of observations includes all members of the U.S. House of Representatives serving in the 105th–119th Congresses who made at least one committee hearing statement and served in at least one Congress both before and after *Dobbs*. This restriction ensures that estimates reflect within-legislator changes in speech rather than compositional changes in membership. Statements are coded as pre-*Dobbs* or post-*Dobbs* using May 2, 2022—the date of the draft opinion leak—as the dividing threshold.

Pre–post model: Our first specification averages the proportion of legislators’ abortion statements before and after *Dobbs*. We then estimate a pre–post DiD model with a party and treatment date interaction, with samples disaggregated by legislators’ gender:

$$Y_{it} = \alpha + \beta_1 (PostDobbs_t \times Democrat_i) + \mu_i + \varepsilon_{it}, \quad (3)$$

where Y_{it} denotes the proportion of hearing statements referencing abortion made by legislator i in Congress t , $PostDobbs_t$ is an indicator equal to 1 for post-Dobbs Congresses and 0 otherwise, $Democrat_i$ indicates party affiliation, and where μ_i are legislator fixed effects that absorb all time-invariant characteristics of individual members. The coefficient β_1 captures the average change in abortion attention among Democrats relative to Republicans after *Dobbs*.

Two-way fixed effects (TWFE) model: We next estimate a two-way fixed effects (TWFE) panel model of the DiD to account for unobserved heterogeneity across legislators and time:

$$Y_{it} = \alpha + \beta_1(PostDobbs_t \times Democrat_i) + \mu_i + \lambda_t + \varepsilon_{it}, \quad (4)$$

where μ_i are legislator fixed effects that absorb all time-invariant characteristics of individual members, and λ_t are Congress fixed effects that account for period-specific shocks common to all legislators.

All DiD models are estimated using ordinary least squares (OLS) regression with robust standard errors clustered by legislator. The coefficient β_1 (Post Dobbs x Democrat) represents the differential change in abortion attention among Democrats relative to Republicans following *Dobbs*. In both specifications, models are estimated separately by gender.

Parallel Trends Assumption

Difference-in-differences (DiD) designs rely on a key identifying assumption: in the absence of treatment, the treated and comparison groups would have experienced similar trends in the outcome of interest (Angrist and Pischke. 2008). When this assumption holds, post-treatment divergence can be attributed to the treatment rather than preexisting differences in trends.

In our study, the treatment is the *Dobbs* draft opinion leak, and the outcome is the proportion of legislators’ hearing statements referencing abortion. Because all legislators are exposed to the treatment, our modified DiD estimates the differential change in abortion attention between Democrats and Republicans, disaggregated by gender. The parallel trends assumption, therefore, implies that, prior to the leak, the party- and gender-specific changes in abortion attention would have followed roughly the same trajectory from one Congress to the next. That is, groups could differ in their baseline level of attention to abortion, but the *trend* should be stable absent treatment.

The main threat to identification arises if abortion attention was already diverging by party or gender before *Dobbs*—for instance, if Democratic women were gradually increasing their attention relative to other groups. To assess the plausibility of parallel trends, we implement a series of descriptive and model-based tests. These include an alternative treatment specification, a randomization-in-time placebo test, evaluation of median pre-*Dobbs* differences by party and gender, a 16-month pre-*Dobbs* event study, and lagged fixed effects estimations. Across all tests, we find no evidence of pre-existing divergence, supporting the credibility of the parallel trends assumption in our design.

Alternative Treatment Date Design

To empirically test whether there are effects for other potential treatment dates, we estimate the pre-/post- *Dobbs* DiD reported in text with two alternative treatment dates: 1) the Court’s grant of certiorari (May 17, 2021) and 2) the day of the official Court decision (June 24, 2022). As expected, the party-based differences for each gender subgroup are substantively negligible and statistically insignificant when the treatment date corresponds to events that took place prior to the *Dobbs* leak (i.e., Certiorari). When the treatment date is assigned the day of the official decision, however, the observed results are consistent with the in-text results, reinforcing the fact that treatment effects initially occurred as a result of the leak—and were durable through the date of the decision. The results from the alternative specifications are presented below in Appendix Table 1.

Appendix Table 1: Pre-Post Models of Abortion Statements by Event Date

	<i>DV: Proportion of Abortion Statements</i>			
	Cert Granted (May 17, 2021)		Official Decision (June 24, 2022)	
	Female Legislators	Male Legislators	Female Legislators	Male Legislators
Post Event	0.007* (0.004)	0.003*** (0.001)	−0.008** (0.004)	0.004* (0.002)
Democrat	0.006*** (0.002)	−0.006*** (0.001)	−0.008** (0.003)	0.008*** (0.002)
Post × Democrat	−0.001 (0.004)	−0.00004 (0.001)	0.022*** (0.006)	0.008 (0.006)
Intercept	−0.001 (0.002)	0.013*** (0.0004)	0.010*** (0.002)	0.011*** (0.001)
Legislator FE	✓	✓	✓	✓
Observations	235	585	208	540
Adjusted R ²	0.615	0.662	0.561	0.530

Note: Standard errors are clustered by legislator and are reported in parentheses. * $p < 0.1$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$.

Randomized Treatment Date Placebo Test

We conduct a randomization-in-time placebo test to assess whether randomly assigning the date of the *Dobbs* draft opinion leak produces a treatment effect. If *Dobbs* was the unique cause of the observed change in legislators' attention to abortion, randomly assigned treatment dates should produce null results. To test this logic, we subset the corpus of unique committee hearing transcripts to include only hearings with a recorded date ($n = 17,357$). We then simulate 2,000 placebo treatment dates, each randomly drawn from the set of observed hearing dates that occurred prior to the *Dobbs* draft opinion leak on May 2, 2022. For each simulated date, we reconstruct the pre/post indicator, calculating the proportion of abortion statements each legislator makes before and after the (fictional) leak dates. We then re-estimate the pre-post DiD model with legislator fixed effects by gender.

$$\text{share}_{i,\text{period}} \sim \text{PostDobbs} \times \text{Democrat} + \text{FE}_i,$$

Members are retained in the sample only if they have observations on both sides of the simulated cutoff. Across 2,000 simulations, 98.2% of placebo models for female legislators and 97.4% for male legislators yield $p > 0.05$ on the *PostDobbs* $\times$ *Democrat* interaction term. Put differently, almost none of the randomly assigned pre-*Dobbs* dates produce a treatment effect. This pattern strengthens our claim that the parallel trends assumption holds for our research design and that meaningful gender-based party difference emerge only after the *Dobbs* draft opinion leak. See Panel C in Figure 2 (in-text).

Median Pre-*Dobbs* Differences in Abortion Attention by Gender and Party

Another way we test the parallel trends assumption is to examine differences in attention to abortion across congressional terms before *Dobbs*. For each Congress from the 105th through the 116th Congress (the last fully pre-treated congressional term), we calculate the median difference between Democratic and Republican legislators in the share of committee hearing statements that

reference abortion. We evaluate whether there are partisan gaps in abortion attention for female and male legislators prior to *Dobbs*. Across the pre-*Dobbs* period, the median partisan difference in abortion attention remained near zero across both samples. The absence of term-level differences of party-based attention to abortion indicates that both female and male legislators followed parallel trends prior to treatment, consistent with the identifying assumption that any subsequent divergence reflects a treatment effect rather than evidence of pre-existing trends.

16 Month Event Study

To conduct a stricter test of the parallel trends assumption, we estimate a dynamic monthly DiD model that spans the 16 months preceding the *Dobbs* leak (January 2021 - April 2022). More specifically, we estimate a regression model in which abortion attention is a function of monthly indicators for the pre-*Dobbs* period, interacting each with party, and including legislator fixed effects with robust standard errors clustered by legislator. Models are estimated separately by legislators' gender. Across both female and male legislators, all pre-*Dobbs* monthly coefficients are statistically indistinguishable from zero, and none exhibit any directional pattern. These findings indicate that even under this more sensitive, month-level specification, abortion attention among Democrats and Republicans evolved in parallel prior to *Dobbs*. See Panel B in Figure 2 (in-text).

Lagged Two-Way Fixed Effects Estimation

To demonstrate the absence of treatment effects prior to *Dobbs*, we also leverage a two-way fixed effects (TWFE) estimator. The TWFE estimator allows us to estimate models with lagged treatment indicators, which serve as falsification tests for pre-treatment differences. If attention to abortion had already begun diverging at an unbalanced rate between Democrats and Republicans prior to *Dobbs*, these lagged coefficients would differ significantly from zero. We estimate separate TWFE models for female and male legislators, lagging the *Dobbs* treatment indicator by one, two, and three congressional terms. Each model includes legislator and term fixed effects. The lag coefficients capture the estimated "effect" of *Dobbs* when the post-treatment indicator is artificially imposed on earlier periods, allowing us to detect any premature divergence in each party's atten-

tion to abortion from one Congress to the next, by gender group, that might diagnose a violation of the parallel trends identifying assumption of our causal design. Across all specifications, the lagged coefficients are near zero and are not statistically significant. The absence of systematic lagged effects indicates that abortion attention evolved in parallel prior to *Dobbs*. See Panel D in Figure 2 (in-text).

Alternative Model Specifications

In-Text Model Results & Alternative Specifications

The main models reported in-text show that Democratic women increase the share of their committee statements referencing abortion by roughly two percentage points more than Republican women after *Dobbs*, with no effect among men. As robustness checks, we estimate a series of pre-post DiD models that include various combinations of post-*Dobbs*, gender, and party indicators without subsetting by gender. A model with only a post-*Dobbs* indicator suggests that legislators, on average, make more abortion statements after the decision than before ($\beta = 0.007; p = 0.000$). Models that include only a party indicator show no statistically significant difference in attention to abortion after *Dobbs* ($\beta = 0.002; p = 0.18$). Models that include only a gender indicator are statistically significant, indicating that female legislators made slightly more abortion statements than male legislators prior to *Dobbs* ($\beta = 0.004; p = 0.05$). Models that interact a post-*Dobbs* indicator with either a gender or a party indicator (while dropping legislator fixed effects) suggest that Democrats were more likely to mention abortion after *Dobbs* than Republicans ($\beta = 0.008; p = 0.04$); however, no such difference exists between male and female legislators ($\beta = 0.001; p = 0.80$). These results, presented in Appendix Table 2, support our argument that legislators' responses were shaped by gender and party (not one or the other). Finally, a model with a triple interaction between post-*Dobbs*, gender, and party yields a coefficient of 0.017 ($p = 0.02$), indicating that the post-*Dobbs* increase in the Democrat–Republican gap in abortion attention was larger among female legislators than among male legislators.

Appendix Table 2: Subcomponents of DiD Design Predicting Abortion Statements

	DV: Proportion of Abortion Statements					
	1	2	3	4	5	6
Post <i>Dobbs</i>	0.007*** (0.002)			0.003 (0.002)	0.007*** (0.002)	0.005** (0.003)
Female		0.004* (0.002)			−0.008 (0.009)	−0.023*** (0.003)
Democrat			0.003 (0.002)	0.008*** (0.002)		0.009*** (0.003)
Post <i>Dobbs</i> x Female					0.001 (0.004)	−0.014*** (0.004)
Post <i>Dobbs</i> x Democrat				0.008** (0.004)		0.004 (0.005)
Female x Democrat						0.030*** (0.005)
Post <i>Dobbs</i> x Female x Democrat						0.017** (0.007)
Intercept	0.010*** (0.001)	0.006*** (0.001)	0.006*** (0.001)	0.012*** (0.001)	0.010*** (0.001)	0.011*** (0.001)
Legislator FE	✓	✗	✗	✓	✓	✓
Observations	788	788	788	788	788	788
Adjusted R ²	0.529	0.004	0.002	0.534	0.529	0.538

Note: Standard errors are clustered by legislator and are reported in parentheses. * $p < 0.1$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$.

Committee Fixed Effects

In the main text, we do not include committee fixed effects because our interest is Congress-wide attention to abortion rather than committee-specific effects. One concern, however, is selection: legislators who wish to speak about abortion may sort into issue-relevant committees, creating more opportunities to make abortion statements. To address this alternative explanation, we re-estimate our TWFE model with member, term, and committee fixed effects at the legislator–committee–term level. The outcome variable is the proportion of a legislator’s statements in a

given committee–term that reference abortion. The independent variable is the interaction between a post-*Dobbs* indicator and a Democratic Party indicator, and we estimate models separately by gender. Results are robust. Among women, Democrats referenced abortion about one percentage point more than Republican women ($p = 0.05$). Among men, Democrats and Republicans did not differ ($\beta = 0.00$, $p = 0.80$). These patterns indicate that committee selection is unlikely to drive our main findings.

Appendix Table 3: Main TWFE Model with Committee Fixed Effects

	<i>DV: Proportion of Abortion Statements</i>	
	Female Legislators	Male Legislators
Post <i>Dobbs</i>	−0.009 (0.006)	−0.0004 (0.003)
Democrat	−0.015** (0.006)	−0.004*** (0.001)
Post <i>Dobbs</i> × Democrat	0.010* (0.005)	0.001 (0.003)
Intercept	0.006 (0.006)	0.0002 (0.003)
Legislator FE	✓	✓
Committee FE	✓	✓
Term FE	✓	✓
Observations	2,885	10,296
Adjusted R ²	0.124	0.140

Note: Standard errors are clustered by legislator and are reported in parentheses. * $p < 0.1$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$.

Logged Share of Abortion Attention

The outcome variable, attention to abortion, is right-skewed: most legislators make few abortion statements per period, while a minority make many. To ensure that this skewness does not drive our results, we apply a natural-log transformation to the dependent variables, $\log(y + 1)$. Results are substantively unchanged across both specifications. In the pre–post model, Democratic women

make about 2 percentage points more abortion statements than Republican women ($p = 0.000$), while the party difference among men is not statistically significant ($p = 0.38$). The TWFE DiD shows the same pattern (**Women:** $\beta = 0.008$, $p = 0.02$; **Men:** $\beta = -0.0003$, $p = 0.72$).

Appendix Table 4: Logged Proportion of Abortion Statements Model Specification

	<i>DV: Logged Proportion of Abortion Statements</i>			
	Female Legislators		Male Legislators	
	Pre-Post	TWFE	Pre-Post	TWFE
Post <i>Dobbs</i>	−0.008** (0.004)	−0.010** (0.004)	0.005** (0.002)	−0.003 (0.003)
Democrat	−0.008*** (0.002)	−0.009** (0.004)	0.009*** (0.002)	−0.003*** (0.001)
Post <i>Dobbs</i> × Democrat	0.021*** (0.005)	0.008** (0.004)	0.004 (0.004)	−0.0003 (0.001)
Intercept	0.010*** (0.002)	0.010** (0.004)	0.011*** (0.001)	0.004 (0.003)
Legislator FE	✓	✓	✓	✓
Term FE	✗	✓	✗	✓
Observations	226	1,117	562	4,562
Adjusted R ²	0.587	0.409	0.530	0.304

Note: Standard errors are clustered by legislator and are reported in parentheses. * $p < 0.1$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$.

Frequency-Weighted DiD

To ensure our findings are not driven by differences in statement volume, we re-estimate both DiD specifications using frequency weights equal to each member–period’s total number of statements, retaining legislator fixed effects and clustering standard errors by member. Results are substantively unchanged. In the pre–post model, Democratic women mention abortion 1.16 percentage points more than Republican women post-*Dobbs* ($p = 0.000$), while the partisan gap among men is not statistically significant ($\beta = 0.001$, $p = 0.43$). The TWFE DiD yields the same pattern: Demo-

cratic women mention abortion 0.6 percentage points more than Republican women after *Dobbs* ($p = 0.02$), with no significant party difference among men ($p = 0.40$). These weighted estimates closely track the unweighted results, indicating that our findings are not driven by variation in total statement volume.

Appendix Table 5: Frequency-Weighted DiD Models of Abortion Attention by Gender (Log Outcome)

	<i>DV: Logged Proportion of Abortion Statements</i>			
	Female Legislators		Male Legislators	
	Pre-Post	TWFE	Pre-Post	TWFE
Post <i>Dobbs</i>	−0.004*** (0.001)	−0.008** (0.004)	0.003*** (0.001)	−0.0002 (0.002)
Democrat	0.001* (0.001)	−0.010*** (0.004)	0.007*** (0.001)	−0.002** (0.001)
Post <i>Dobbs</i> × Democrat	0.011*** (0.002)	0.006** (0.003)	0.001 (0.001)	0.001 (0.001)
Intercept	0.007*** (0.001)	0.008** (0.004)	0.006*** (0.0001)	0.001 (0.001)
Legislator FE	✓	✓	✓	✓
Term FE	✗	✓	✗	✓
Observations	226	1,117	562	4,562
Adjusted R ²	0.603	0.469	0.661	0.444

Note: Standard errors are clustered by legislator and are reported in parentheses. * $p < 0.1$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$.

Durability of DiD Effects

We assess how long the increase in attention to abortion among Democratic women persists after *Dobbs* by splitting the post period into three bins: the second half of the 117th Congress (on/after May 2, 2022), the 118th, and the 119th. For male and female legislators, we estimate a TWFE DiD model with legislator fixed effects and period dummies, using the share of a legislator’s hearing statements that reference abortion before and after as the outcome. The independent variable is

an interaction term between the post-treatment indicator and Democrat, which captures the differential change by party, relative to the pre-*Dobbs* period. We then conduct Wald tests of (i) joint significance of all post-*Dobbs* interactions and (ii) equality of effects across the three post bins. For women, the joint post-*Dobbs* effect is statistically significant (**Wald** $\chi^2(3) = 8.95$, $p = 0.03$); for men it is not ($\chi^2(3) = 2.58$, $p = 0.46$). Effects are statistically indistinguishable across the three post bins for both women and men (**Women:** $\chi^2(2) = 0.25$, $p = 0.884$; **Men:** $\chi^2(2) = 2.23$, $p = 0.328$), indicating that the treatment effect among Democratic women persists through the 119th without detectable decay and is absent among men. Point estimates for women are roughly 1.5 to 2.3 percentage points across bins.

Contextualizing Magnitude of Effect

Our results indicate that female Democrats increased their attention to abortion by roughly two percentage points relative to female Republicans after *Dobbs*, with no change among men. Is a two percentage point shift in committee hearing attention substantively large? We contextualize the magnitude of our findings in two ways.

First, we compare the pre–post change in abortion attention around four other consequential abortion-policy events that occur in our time series: passage of the Partial-Birth Abortion Ban Act (November 5, 2003), *Gonzalez v. Carhart* (April 18, 2007), *Whole Woman’s Health v. Hellerstedt* (June 27, 2016), and *June Medical Services, LLC v. Russo* (June 29, 2020). Using our measure of abortion statements, we estimate pre-post DiD models comparing proportional attention to abortion before and after each event by gender (women vs. men) and party (Democrats vs. Republicans). Appendix Tables 6-9 indicate that all four events produced smaller gender- and party-based changes in congressional attention to abortion than *Dobbs*. Three out of four of the events produce statistically insignificant changes in Female Democrats’ attention to abortion. Female Democrats did increase their attention to abortion after *Whole Woman’s Health v. Hellersedt*. However, the increase is substantively negligible (0.2 percentage points). These results should be interpreted as descriptive, given that we do not assess whether the parallel trends assumptions holds in each case.

Appendix Table 6: TWFE DiD Models of Abortion Attention — Partial-Birth Abortion Ban (2003)

	<i>DV: Proportion of Abortion Statements</i>			
	Female Legislators		Male Legislators	
	Pre-Post	TWFE	Pre-Post	TWFE
Post Treatment	−0.00002 (0.001)	−0.00002 (0.001)	−0.0004 (0.001)	−0.0004 (0.001)
Democrat	0.004*** (0.001)	0.004*** (0.001)	0.001 (0.001)	0.001 (0.001)
Post × Democrat	0.003 (0.002)	0.003 (0.002)	−0.002 (0.002)	−0.002 (0.002)
Intercept	0.00001 (0.0005)	0.00001 (0.0005)	0.0002 (0.0004)	0.0002 (0.0004)
Legislator FE	✓	✓	✓	✓
Term FE	✗	✓	✗	✓
Observations	112	112	686	686
Adjusted R ²	0.604	0.604	0.557	0.557

Note: Standard errors are clustered by legislator and are reported in parentheses. * $p < 0.1$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$.

Appendix Table 7: TWFE DiD Models of Abortion Attention — *Gonzalez v. Carhart* (2007)

	<i>DV: Proportion of Abortion Statements</i>			
	Female Legislators		Male Legislators	
	Pre-Post	TWFE	Pre-Post	TWFE
Post Treatment	0.001 (0.001)	0.001 (0.001)	0.00004 (0.001)	0.00004 (0.001)
Democrat	0.010*** (0.001)	0.010*** (0.001)	0.001 (0.0004)	0.001 (0.0004)
Post × Democrat	−0.0003 (0.001)	−0.0003 (0.001)	0.0001 (0.001)	0.0001 (0.001)
Intercept	−0.001 (0.001)	−0.001 (0.001)	−0.00002 (0.0003)	−0.00002 (0.0003)
Legislator FE	✓	✓	✓	✓
Term FE	✗	✓	✗	✓
Observations	136	136	720	720
Adjusted R ²	0.755	0.755	0.651	0.651

Note: Standard errors are clustered by legislator and are reported in parentheses. * $p < 0.1$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$.

Appendix Table 8: TWFE DiD Models of Abortion Attention — *Whole Woman’s Health v. Hellerstedt* (2016)

	<i>DV: Proportion of Abortion Statements</i>			
	Female Legislators		Male Legislators	
	Pre-Post	TWFE	Pre-Post	TWFE
Post Treatment	−0.001 (0.001)	−0.001 (0.001)	−0.0004 (0.0004)	−0.0004 (0.0004)
Democrat	−0.003*** (0.001)	−0.003*** (0.001)	−0.006*** (0.0003)	−0.006*** (0.0003)
Post × Democrat	0.002* (0.001)	0.002* (0.001)	0.0001 (0.001)	0.0001 (0.001)
Intercept	0.003*** (0.0004)	0.003*** (0.0004)	0.007*** (0.0002)	0.007*** (0.0002)
Legislator FE	✓	✓	✓	✓
Term FE	✗	✓	✗	✓
Observations	174	174	654	654
Adjusted R ²	0.570	0.570	0.699	0.699

Note: Standard errors are clustered by legislator and are reported in parentheses. * $p < 0.1$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$.

Appendix Table 9: TWFE DiD Models of Abortion Attention — *June Medical Services v. Russo* (2020)

	<i>DV: Proportion of Abortion Statements</i>			
	Female Legislators		Male Legislators	
	Pre-Post	TWFE	Pre-Post	TWFE
Post Treatment	0.003 (0.003)	0.003 (0.003)	0.002*** (0.001)	0.002*** (0.001)
Democrat	−0.001 (0.002)	−0.001 (0.002)	−0.013*** (0.0004)	−0.013*** (0.0004)
Post × Democrat	−0.0003 (0.003)	−0.0003 (0.003)	−0.0003 (0.001)	−0.0003 (0.001)
Intercept	−0.0003 (0.001)	−0.0003 (0.001)	0.012*** (0.0003)	0.012*** (0.0003)
Legislator FE	✓	✓	✓	✓
Term FE	✗	✓	✗	✓
Observations	208	208	588	588
Adjusted R ²	0.681	0.681	0.683	0.683

Note: Standard errors are clustered by legislator and are reported in parentheses. * $p < 0.1$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$.

Second, we benchmark the shift in congressional attention to abortion after *Dobbs* against two other consequential events: *Obergefell* (June 26, 2015), the Supreme Court case that granted marriage equality to same-sex couples, and the murder of George Floyd (May 25, 2020), which was one catalyst of the Black Lives Matter movement. We selected these events for two reasons: like *Dobbs*, *Obergefell* was a consequential Supreme Court decision that reshaped civil rights for a historically marginalized group; and Black Lives Matter was a major social movement that spurred congressional efforts to address police violence (e.g., the George Floyd Justice in Policing Act). While many other cases could be considered, the goal of this exercise is simply to contextualize the magnitude of Congress's attention shift after *Dobbs* relative to other recent events that garnered substantial congressional attention.

To do so, we constructed simple dictionaries of terms related to *Obergefell* and Black Lives Matter, and used them to code each statement as LGBTQ- or race-related. We then collapsed the data to a member-level pre-post event panel, so that each legislator contributes two observations: one before the event and one after. The primary dependent variables are the proportion of LGBTQ- or race-related statements in each period. We then estimate pre-post TWFE models by gender and party. Across both events, the results are either statistically insignificant or substantively negligible. This pattern suggests that *Dobbs* was associated with a large increase in congressional attention, especially when compared to other salient, high-profile events. Again, these results should be interpreted as associations given that we do not assess whether parallel trends holds for each event. Importantly, these benchmarks do not imply that *Obergefell* or Black Lives Matter were less important than *Dobbs*, nor that Congress devoted less overall effort to those issues through other channels (e.g., bill introduction or passage). We present these comparisons solely to help readers interpret the substantive magnitude of our estimates.

Obergefell Dictionary: Obergefell, Marriage Equality, Same Sex Marriage, Gay, Lesbian, Sexual Orientation, Gay Marriage, LGBTQ

Black Lives Matter Dictionary: Black Lives Matter, Police Brutality, Racial Justice, Systemic Racism, Police Violence, Defund the Police

Appendix Table 10: Pre-Post FE DiD Models — *Obergefell* and BLM by Gender

	<i>DV: Proportion of LGBTQ Statements</i>		<i>DV: Proportion of BLM Statements</i>	
	Female Legislators	Male Legislators	Female Legislators	Male Legislators
	<i>Obergefell</i>	<i>Obergefell</i>	<i>BLM</i>	<i>BLM</i>
Post Treatment	0.0001 (0.0001)	0.00005 (0.0006)	0.0004 (0.0004)	0.001*** (0.0002)
Democrat	-0.0003 (0.001)	-0.001*** (0.0004)	0.003*** (0.0003)	-0.0003 (0.0003)
Post Treatment × Democrat	0.0003 (0.006)	0.0005 (0.0004)	0.001** (0.001)	0.001 (0.001)
Intercept	-0.00003 (0.00003)	0.0004*** (0.00003)	-0.0002 (0.0002)	-0.0004*** (0.0001)
Legislator FE	✓	✓	✓	✓
Term FE	✗	✗	✗	✗
Observations	121	513	208	602
Adjusted R ²	0.736	0.780	0.648	0.526

Note: Standard errors are clustered by legislator and are reported in parentheses. * $p < 0.1$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$.

Alternative Dependent Variable: Cosponsorship of Abortion Bills

To assess whether our findings are robust to additional measures of issue attention, we examine legislators' cosponsorship of abortion bills. To do so, we collect data on legislators' cosponsorship decisions from the 111th–118th Congresses. We classify bills as abortion-related if the word “abortion” appears in the bill text. We then compute the proportion of abortion bills each legislator cosponsored before and after *Dobbs*.

Estimating a pre-post DiD model similar to the in-text specification, we find that female Democrats increased abortion-bill cosponsorship relative to female Republicans by 0.8 percentage points ($\beta = 0.008$, $p = 0.006$), with no statistically significant change among men ($\beta = 0.002$, $p = 0.26$). A triple interaction ($\text{Post-Dobbs} \times \text{Democrat} \times \text{Female}$) indicates that the post-*Dobbs* partisan shift is larger among women than among men ($\beta = 0.006$, $p = 0.054$). In each model, we control for the number of abortion bills before and after *Dobbs*.

Overall, these additional models show that the post-*Dobbs* gendered partisan shift is not limited to committee hearings; it also extends to cosponsorship behavior. Together, they indicate that *Dobbs* reshaped legislators' behavior at multiple decision points in the legislative process.

Appendix Table 11: TWFE DiD Models of Cosponsorship of Abortion Bills by Gender

	<i>DV: Proportion of Cosponsored Bills Related to Abortion</i>		
	Female Legislators	Male Legislators	Full Interaction
Post <i>Dobbs</i>	−0.006** (0.003)	−0.001 (0.002)	−0.001 (0.002)
Democrat	−0.007*** (0.001)	−0.006*** (0.001)	−0.006*** (0.001)
Post <i>Dobbs</i> × Democrat	0.008*** (0.003)	−0.046*** (0.0004)	
Post <i>Dobbs</i> × Democrat × Female			0.006* (0.003)
Number of Unique Abortion Bills (Period)	0.008*** (0.003)	0.002 (0.002)	0.002 (0.002)
Intercept	0.010*** (0.001)	0.055*** (0.001)	0.055*** (0.001)
Legislator FE	✓	✓	✓
Term FE	✓	✓	✓
Observations	254	631	885
Adjusted R ²	0.732	0.748	0.753

Note: Standard errors are clustered by legislator and are reported in parentheses. * $p < 0.1$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$.

Placebo Tests: Non-Abortion Issue Areas

As an additional robustness check, we implement a series of negative outcome controls to assess whether the observed post-*Dobbs* shifts in congressional attention are specific to abortion. If our findings are specific to *Dobbs*, and are not produced in other issue areas, this suggests that *Dobbs* likely drives the gender- and electoral-based shifts reported in-text. To do so, we examine whether *Dobbs* is associated with changes in legislators' attention to a set of policy issue areas that are theoretically unrelated to abortion. Using the keyword dictionaries below, we construct measures of issue attention for the following issue areas: housing, guns, immigration, environment, policing, agriculture, and economics.

Housing:housing, affordable housing, public housing, homeless, homelessness, rent, renter, eviction, mortgage, property tax, housing assistance, HUD, low-income housing, housing development, section 8, tenant, housing crisis, subsidized housing, housing policy, housing stability

Guns:2nd amendment, right to bear arms, second amendment, nra, rifle, firearm, gun violence, shootings, assault rifle, assault weapon, automatic weapon, background checks, background check, bump stock, high-capacity magazine, gun, guns

Immigration:immigration, immigrant, border, asylum, refugee, deportation, undocumented, illegal immigrant, visa, green card, citizenship, naturalization, DACA, ICE, customs and border protection, border security, migrant, migration, immigration policy, immigration reform

Environment:environment, environmental, climate change, global warming, greenhouse, pollution, polluting, pollutants, polluters, fossil fuel

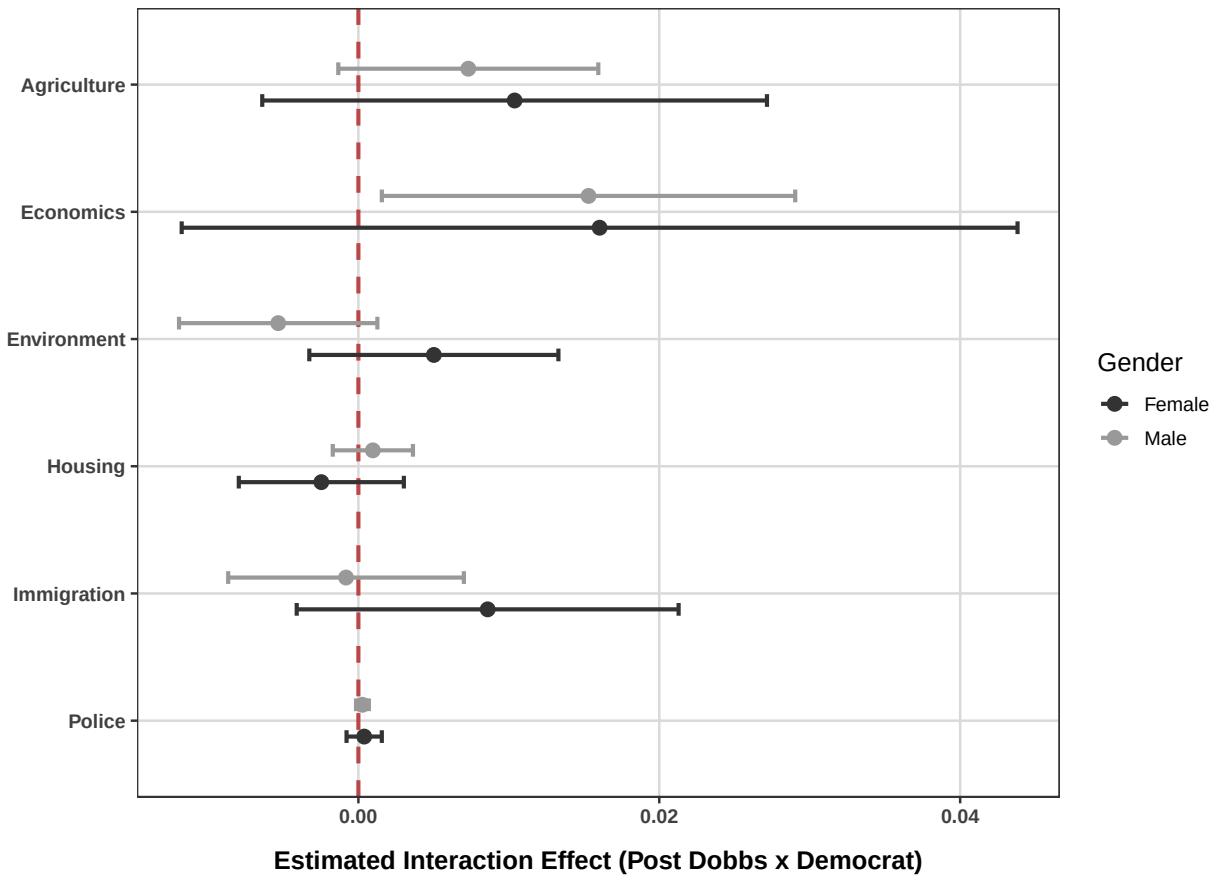
Police: defund the police, abolish, law enforcement, policing, back the blue, police, officer, officers

Agriculture:agriculture, farm, farmer, farming, crops, livestock, agricultural policy, federal farm program, agricultural trade, food security, agribusiness

Economics:economy, gdp, jobs, unemployment, inflation, federal reserve, interest rate, budget, trade, tariff, fiscal policy, monetary policy, deficit, recession, financial regulation

Each dictionary consists of substantively relevant terms commonly used in congressional discourse. We then re-estimate our pre-post difference-in-differences models using each alternative issue attention measure as the dependent variable. *Dobbs* should not systematically affect attention to these unrelated policy domains. Accordingly, we expect null or substantively negligible estimates for the post-*Dobbs* interaction terms in these placebo outcomes. Appendix Figure 1 plots the estimated post-*Dobbs* interaction effects by policy area, separately for male and female legislators. Across all domains, point estimates are small in magnitude and confidence intervals consistently overlap zero. Importantly, there is no systematic pattern by gender or policy area that would suggest a generalized reorientation of issue attention following *Dobbs*. Consistent with these expectations, we find no evidence that *Dobbs* produced meaningful shifts in legislative attention outside the abortion domain. The absence of an effect in other policy areas strengthens our claim that *Dobbs* increased female Democrats attention to abortion, rather than a broader contemporaneous change in congressional attention.

Appendix Figure 1: Non-Abortion Policy Attention Does Not Increase After *Dobbs*



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